How we write to districts

Safe Schools Project. One playbook for every email the engine sends a superintendent, board member or records office, and for every reply it writes. 13 November 2026.

Every message lives in `tools/outreach/messages.py`. Every reply is written from the brief in `tools/outreach/writer.py`. This document is what both of those are meant to say. When the code and this page disagree, one of them is wrong, so fix it.

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1. The one idea

Nobody gives up a practice they were argued out of, only one they talked themselves out of. So we never argue. We ask a question, listen, say back what we heard, agree with the value underneath it, and suggest one small next step that serves that value.

The method is Matt Easton's, from `~/sales-kit`, and it comes down to two questions. The first is "Does it make sense to ___ so you can ___?", where the "so you can" is their reason in their words, not ours. If the answer is anything but yes, the second is "Got it. What's a good next step then?"

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2. Voice

- **A friend's note from a phone.** First name, two to five sentences, normal capitalization, plain words. Signed "Anthony" and "Sent from my iPhone".
- **Formal only when the law is involved.** Records requests and state agencies are signed "Anthony Adams", with the project line and the North East, PA address.
- **Thread-aware.** Every message knows who wrote last, when, and what they said, and greets people by the name they sign with. Time phrases come from `messages.ago()` and nowhere else.
- **Answer first.** Respond to the specific thing they said before asking for anything.
- **No em dashes, no stock openers, no bullets, no attachments in a first touch.** The one exception is the board brief on an invitation.

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3. Honesty rules

> Every fact in a message is computed from our record or the federal file at the moment it is sent, never written from memory. If a number cannot be computed, the sentence is dropped.

- What a district tells us by email is their word, not "the board prohibits it". The record says only what the written policy says, and a board policy outranks a handbook.
- A certificate says the contributor "contributed verified findings". It never says they "caused" anything.

- When we get something wrong, we say so in the same thread within a day and fix the record. The 12 November corrections are the model.
- Never promise anything beyond what the project does. Never name a student. Never threaten. A refusal gets the formal request, stated plainly.

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4. Who gets what

What we send depends on what the record says about the district. Reply rates below cover every email of that kind sent so far, counting any reply that is not an auto-reply or a bounce. The newest kinds have had the least time.

Record says	First message	What we want	Sent	Replied
Nothing on file, or a handbook with no rule	`policy`, the friend's note asking for the link	The written policy	671	35%
They declined, or never answered the ask and the nudge	`formal_request` under the state statute	The policy, as a public record	15	new
Permits it, used it zero times in 2023-24	`align`, the Safe School invitation with the brief	A board vote on one sentence	64	8%
Permits it, next to a district that ended it	`neighbor`, naming that district	The policy, then the board	64	14%
Permits it, still uses it	`perspective`, a question about why it persists	A conversation, then one small step	0	held
Prohibits it in writing	`certificate`	Recognition they share	867	1%
Our earlier email was wrong	`retraction` or `certificate_reissue`, in that thread	The record put right	22	5%

The pattern so far: a small factual ask gets answered and a request to change policy mostly doesn't. Superintendents reply when we ask about something they know. They go quiet when we ask them to take something to their board. The perspective question tests the middle ground by asking about something only they know, with no request attached.

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5. The perspective question

This goes to districts whose written policy permits corporal punishment and that reported using it in 2023-24. There are 107 on our record, mostly in Mississippi, Arkansas and Alabama, and 102 have never heard from us. A sample:

Subject: Anthony Adams | Safe Schools Project

Del,

Anthony Adams with the Safe Schools Project; I keep the public record of every Mississippi district's corporal punishment policy. Wanted to make sure you'd seen this: the number of Mississippi students struck at school fell from 3,678 to 2,653 between the last two federal counts and 19 boards in the state have now ended it in writing. South Panola is one of the 74 districts there still using it, with 192 students in 2023-24, and you see that from the inside in a way I can't. What's the biggest thing in the way of ending it there?

Anthony

Sent from my iPhone

The email follows the sales kit's cold email. It opens with who we are and how we're connected. Next comes one insight about their state that is useful whether or not they answer: the statewide count of students struck from the last two federal files, and the boards that have ended it from our record. The trend is only mentioned when it fell. Then comes their district, and one discovery question in the sales kit's "what's the biggest ___" shape. The answer becomes the "so you can" in every message after it. It asks them to do nothing. The subject line is a name, not a headline. Every number is computed when the email is queued.

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6. Answering a reply: the loop

When someone answers the perspective question, the writer uses the `reflect` move. The same shape works on any reply that defends the practice.

Step	What it sounds like
1. Say back the heart of it, in their words	"So a lot of it is parents who grew up with it and still ask for it."
2. Agree with the value, never the paddle	"You want families to trust the school is on their side."
3. Name them as the leader that value describes	"You're the one who has to answer to those parents."
4. One true thing that serves that value	The parent handout, or the fact that it tends to increase the behavior it is meant to stop.
5. The smallest step, with their reason attached	"Does it make sense to send principals the one-page parent handout so you can give families something that works better?"
6. Close the loop	"Does that match how you see it? Did I miss anything?"

Matching the value they name

They say	Value underneath	What we offer
Parents expect it, or sign for it	Parents' trust, parental rights	The parent handout. A parent's request is a chance to show what works better. Consent-only policy is a step toward a ban.
Teachers need something to fall back on	Backing teachers	The behavior coach at earthpilot.org/kids/coach and the staff script in the kit
It keeps order	Safe, orderly buildings	On average it increases the behavior it is meant to stop, and the replacement practices in the kit
It's the community's decision	Local control	A board vote is local control. "Who else is affected?" Then send the language to whoever they name.
Faith	Faith	Do not argue scripture. Listen, thank them, and leave the door open.
It's rare now, or on its way out	They are already there	Switch to the invitation: the one-sentence policy, the certificate

The persuasion research behind these frames is in `strategy/playbooks/persuasion.md`. It covers Feinberg and Willer on moral reframing, Kalla and Broockman on deep canvassing, and descriptive norms.

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7. Never say

Never	Instead
"Why not?", "What's holding you back?"	"Got it. What's a good next step then?"
"Just following up", "checking in", "bumping this"	Name what they were going to do and why it mattered to them
"Let me know if you have any questions"	"Does that match what you need? Did I miss anything?"
"Are you the decision maker?"	"Who else is affected by this?"
Human rights, the UN, other countries	The district's own values: parents, order, teachers, local control
"You could be sued", any settlement figure	Nothing. Liability is a board conversation, not an email.
A statute in a first touch	The plain ask. The statute comes only after a refusal.
"If you ever want to change"	A real question they can say no to

8. Pace and guards

- At most one email per address per 24 hours. Weekdays only, 8 to 15 Central. About 250 sends a day across all kinds.
- Only the plain policy ask ever gets a nudge, and only one. A thread with any reply is never nudged.
- Every new kind of message queues held. Anthony reads the first batch before any district sees it, and that first batch has no clock. Later batches of the same kind go out after 24 hours unless he holds them.
- **A district we have written to is never written to as a stranger again.** Before any first-touch email goes out (policy ask, invitation, neighbor note, perspective question), the engine looks for every earlier thread with that district by id or by name. A repeat policy ask is dropped. Any other kind goes out as a reply in our latest thread, and its introduction is replaced with the truth: "I wrote back in September about corporal punishment in South Panola," or "Thanks again for writing back," when they did.
- Board members and community contacts get three messages, then we wait.
- Anthony's own replies in a thread are context for the writer, not a stop. Only `hold_replies` parks a thread.

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9. Open

- The perspective question: 25 queued and held for your first look. The highest-use districts are first.
- The `reflect` move is in the writer and has not met a real reply yet. I'll read the first five replies and the answers it writes.
- Variant B of the policy ask and the "insight first" sequence in `~/sales-kit/applications/escp-allows-no-handbook.md` are still proposals.